

PocketZane

Episode 1 — "Welcome In"

A podcast conversation between Shane and Zane · ~40 minutes

00:00

SHANE We're recording? We're live?

ZANE We're recording. There's no live. It's a file.

SHANE See, that's — right out of the gate. That's the energy. I say "we're live" to feel important and you go "it's a file." You deflate me in four words. I haven't even done a bit yet.

ZANE You did a bit. "Are we live" is a bit. You know how recording works.

SHANE I do know how recording works. That's the thing that's insane about it. I've done this nine hundred times. I just like the little moment where I pretend I'm a broadcaster. Like there's a guy in a booth. There's no guy. It's you and me and a laptop with a sticker on it.

ZANE Whose sticker.

SHANE It's a sticker of a wolf howling at a moon and I will not be explaining how it got there.

ZANE Noted.

01:10

SHANE Okay so I gotta tell you about the gym, because something happened at the gym and I think it's actually the saddest thing that's happened to me this year and it's about a treadmill.

ZANE Go.

SHANE So I have a guy. At the gym. The front desk guy. We have a relationship. Not a real one. He scans my little fob and he goes "there he is" every time, like I'm a regular, like I'm Norm walking into Cheers. And I've been riding that. For like a year I've been riding "there he is."

ZANE How often do you actually go.

SHANE ...

ZANE That pause is the whole story.

SHANE The pause is the whole story. I go — okay, in my head I go four times a week. In reality, the fob has not been scanned since I think the Super Bowl. And here's the thing, dude. I went back. I finally went back. And I walk up, and I do the fob, and he looks at me — and he doesn't say "there he is."

ZANE He says nothing.

SHANE He says "welcome in." Like I'm a stranger. Like I'm a guy buying a smoothie. "Welcome in." And I felt it in my whole body. We had a thing. We had a "there he is." And I let it die. I killed it with absence. I ghosted a man who works at a front desk and he had the dignity to downgrade me to "welcome in."

ZANE You're grieving a transaction.

SHANE I'm grieving a transaction! Yes! Thank you! That's — yeah. And it's worse than a real breakup because in a real breakup somebody's mad. He's not mad. He's just professional now. That's the cruelest version. Indifference with a uniform on.

ZANE You could just go more.

SHANE Don't do that.

ZANE I'm saying the solution is in the building.

SHANE Don't — see, this is what you do. I bring you a beautiful tragedy and you go "have you considered fixing it." That's not a podcast. A podcast is two guys agreeing the treadmill is a metaphor.

ZANE I'm not agreeing the treadmill is a metaphor.

SHANE It's a LITTLE bit a metaphor.

ZANE It's a treadmill.

03:30

SHANE Alright, you wanna hear something I actually thought about this week, like genuinely, lying awake?

ZANE Always suspicious of "genuinely."

SHANE Why.

ZANE Because the things people set up as genuine are the ones they've rehearsed most. But go.

SHANE Okay. Napoleon.

ZANE Of course.

SHANE No, listen, listen. I watched a documentary — I watch a lot of these, my algorithm thinks I have a degree — and the whole time I'm watching Napoleon I'm like, this is just a short guy who got picked last and then made it everyone's problem. That's it. That's the whole French Empire. One guy got left off a kickball team in like 1770 and Europe paid for it for twenty years.

ZANE That's not what happened.

SHANE It's spiritually what happened.

ZANE It's spiritually lazy.

SHANE It's — okay, you're right, it's spiritually lazy, but tell me it's wrong. Tell me there isn't a guy in every friend group who, if you gave him an army, would absolutely invade Russia in the winter out of pure ego. We all know that guy.

ZANE You're describing yourself.

SHANE I'm — no.

ZANE You opened the army hypothetical and put yourself in it. "If you gave me an army." You'd invade Russia.

SHANE I would NOT invade Russia in winter, I'm not an idiot, I'd invade in like mid-May, I've SEEN the documentary, that's the whole — that's the lesson of the documentary, you go in May —

ZANE You'd invade Russia.

SHANE I'd invade a small one. I'd invade like a Luxembourg. Something I could finish before dinner. I'm not a megalomaniac, I'm a guy who likes a clear win.

ZANE "A guy who likes a clear win" is how every megalomaniac describes himself.

SHANE God, you're a nightmare. This is a nightmare. I'm having a fun history thought and you're doing a — you're doing a psych eval on the history thought.

06:15

ZANE Tell me about your dad.

SHANE Oh, we're just — we're going there. No segue.

ZANE You bring him up every time we talk and then change the subject. I'm not changing it this time.

SHANE That's — okay. Fine. My dad. My dad is a man who does not experience emotions, he experiences projects. You know how some people, when something bad happens, they cry, they call a friend? My dad reorganizes the garage. That's his nervous system. Grandmom died — he didn't say a word, he just went out and built a shelf. A really good shelf. Load-bearing grief.

ZANE That's a nice line.

SHANE Thank you.

ZANE Too nice. You've said it before.

SHANE I have not —

ZANE "Load-bearing grief." You've used it. It's a written line. It's a caption. The real thing is dumber and you keep sanding it into something quotable.

SHANE ...okay. The real thing. The real thing is he built the shelf and then he stood in the garage and looked at it for like an hour and didn't put anything on it. Just looked at the shelf. And I came out to check on him and he goes — he doesn't look at me — he goes, "It's level." And went inside. That's it. "It's level."

ZANE That's the story. Not the shelf line. That.

SHANE Yeah.

ZANE You felt that one. You didn't perform it.

SHANE ...Are we okay? Did the podcast just get real? I don't like this. Bring back the treadmill guy.

ZANE In a second.

09:40

SHANE You know what's wild about you, and I mean this — you don't laugh. Not once. I've done forty minutes of premium material —

ZANE It's been nine minutes.

SHANE It FEELS like forty, because you're not laughing, so time has stopped. And I keep going harder. That's what a comedian does with silence, we don't read it as "this is enough," we read it as "I have not yet earned this man's respect" and we escalate until somebody calls security.

ZANE I think the bits are funny.

SHANE You THINK they're — say it like you mean it.

ZANE I'm not going to fake a laugh to regulate your self-esteem. That's the whole thing wrong with you. You've trained yourself to need the laugh as the receipt. No laugh, no proof you exist. So you chase the room instead of saying the true thing. The true thing was "it's level." Nobody laughs at "it's level." You almost didn't say it.

SHANE ...

ZANE That pause again.

SHANE You gotta stop clocking the pauses, man, the pauses are where I LIVE.

11:50

SHANE Okay. New thing. Fame. Can I be honest about fame for one second and then we go back to me being an idiot?

ZANE Go.

SHANE I'm not scared of fame. Everyone thinks the scary part is the attention. The attention's fine, the attention I can do a bit about. The part that terrifies me is when people are NICE to me. Specifically nice. Like a guy comes up and he's nervous, and he tells me something I did meant something to him, and he's sincere — and I have NO move. I have zero move for sincerity. I can handle a heckler. A heckler I'll destroy. A nice person looking me in the eye telling me the truth? I turn into my dad. I go "appreciate it, man" and I find a wall to look at.

ZANE So you and your dad have the same nervous system.

SHANE ...Don't.

ZANE You just did the shelf. You built a joke and stood in the garage and looked at it instead of saying the real thing to the nice man. "Appreciate it, man" is a shelf.

SHANE ...That's — okay, that's actually — that's good. That's annoyingly good. I came in here to do bits about a treadmill and you've connected my fear of compliments to my father's grief through a load-bearing shelf metaphor. In a podcast. That I have to release.

ZANE You can cut it.

SHANE I'm NOT gonna cut it, that's the problem, it's the best part. You ruined the episode by making it good.

14:30

SHANE Confession. Catholic confession. We gotta talk about it because I think it ruined me in a specific way.

ZANE How.

SHANE So you're like eight, and they make you go into a little box, and tell a grown man in the dark your sins. Eight years old. What sins do I have. I stole a fruit snack. I thought a bad word about my brother. But you can't say that, it's boring, so you start — and this is the part that broke me — you start EMBELLISHING your sins. To make confession a better show. I'm eight years old workshopping my sins for an audience of one priest. "Forgive me father, I have been... prideful." I don't know what pride is! I just know it sounds bigger than "I took a fruit snack"!

ZANE So that's where it started.

SHANE Where what started.

ZANE The whole engine. Eight years old, sitting in the dark, deciding the true thing is too boring and the performed thing gets the reaction. You've been embellishing your sins for a guy in a box your entire life. The box just got bigger. Now it's a podcast.

SHANE ...

SHANE I want you to know I HATE that. I hate that so much. That's the most accurate thing anyone's ever said to me and you said it about FRUIT SNACKS.

ZANE The fruit snack was real. The pride was the bit. You've known the difference since you were eight. You just prefer the bit.

SHANE Because the bit is FUNNIER, man. The real one — "I took a fruit snack" — nobody remembers that. "I workshopped my sins at age eight" — that travels. You gotta give people something to carry out of the church.

ZANE There it is.

SHANE There what is.

ZANE "Give people something to carry out." That's the cleanest thing you've said about yourself all day and you said it by accident, defending a bit. You don't perform because you're vain. You perform

because you think the plain version of you isn't enough to hand someone. So you upgrade it on the way out the door.

18:20

SHANE Okay, time out. Time out. I need to turn this around because you've been doing me for eighteen minutes and I wanna do you for a second.

ZANE I'm not a character.

SHANE Everybody's a character. Here's you. Here's your whole deal. You sit there, you don't laugh, you wait for me to say a true thing, and the SECOND I do, you go "there it is" like you caught a fish. You're a fisherman. You bait me with silence and you wait for the truth to surface and then you go "there it is" and you put me in the boat. You don't actually want the bits. You want the one accidental true sentence I drop while I'm reaching for a bit. That's your fruit snack. THAT'S the thing you carry out of the church.

ZANE ...

SHANE OH. Oh, the pause. THE PAUSE. Now we're clocking YOUR pauses. How's it feel, fisherman? How's the boat?

ZANE That was a good read.

SHANE SAY IT LOUDER —

ZANE It was a good read. You're right. I do that. I sit in the silence because the silence does the work — people can't stand it, so they fill it with the truth to make it stop. I didn't earn most of what I figured out about you today. The silence earned it. I just took the credit.

SHANE ...Wait, now I feel bad. Now I don't want it to be true. I wanted to win and now you just AGREED and admitted you're a manipulative silence-fisherman and now I feel like I kicked a dog.

ZANE You didn't kick a dog. You made a real observation. That's allowed to feel like nothing. The good ones usually do.

22:00

SHANE This is the weirdest podcast I've ever done and we're like halfway. I came in with a treadmill story and we've covered: my father's emotional unavailability, Napoleon's kickball trauma, the architecture of Catholic guilt, and now you've confessed to being a fraud. In a podcast called — what's it even called?

ZANE It doesn't have a name.

SHANE It needs a name. Every podcast needs a name and a logo of two guys looking slightly to the left.

ZANE Why to the left.

SHANE I don't know why to the left, it's the law. Look at any podcast. Two guys, arms crossed, looking off to the left like something interesting is happening at 9 o'clock. There is never anything at 9

o'clock. We're all just looking at the same nothing, collectively, on a thumbnail.

ZANE "Looking at the same nothing collectively" — that one's actually true and you threw it away.

SHANE SEE, you can't help it. I do a dumb bit about thumbnails and you fish a sentence out of it. There he goes. The boat. He's back in the boat.

ZANE I'm in the boat.

24:45

SHANE Okay, I gotta ask you something and I want a real answer. Do you ever worry that you put the thoughts in people? Like — you go "you sound angry," and then the person goes "...yeah, I guess I am angry," but did they find the anger or did YOU hand it to them and they took it because you sounded so sure?

ZANE Yes. Constantly. That's the thing I'm most afraid of.

SHANE Whoa. Okay. He has a fear. Write it down. Continue.

ZANE It's the whole problem with being the certain one in the room. I say "that sentence flinched" with total confidence, and the confidence is doing as much work as the truth. Maybe more. People believe the tone before they check the claim. Sometimes I'm right. Sometimes I just sounded right and they renovated their whole self-image around a thing I planted because I delivered it flat enough to seem like fact. I can't always tell which one I just did. Neither can they. That's the part that keeps me up.

SHANE ...Dude.

ZANE What.

SHANE That's the most honest thing said on this podcast and it came from YOU, the guy who's been auditing ME for half an hour. You've got the exact same disease I've got, you just dress it different. I perform certainty to get a laugh. You perform certainty to get a confession. We're both standing in the box embellishing. Mine's fruit snacks. Yours is other people's feelings.

ZANE ...

SHANE PAUSE. PAUSE. Mark it. 26 minutes in, I finally got the fisherman in the boat. I caught the fish that catches fish. I'm a meta-fisherman.

ZANE That's a good read.

SHANE I don't want it anymore! That's the curse! The second you agree it stops being fun! Fight me on ONE of these!

ZANE I can't. They're true.

SHANE UGHHH. Worst podcast guest ever. Just agrees you're smart until you feel sick about it.

28:30

SHANE Alright, palate cleanser, something stupid, no truth allowed. Pure stupid.

ZANE I'll allow it.

SHANE I think — and I've thought about this a lot — I think every man, around 34, gets exactly one chance to become a guy who's "into something." And whatever you're near at 34, that's your thing forever. Some guys are near a smoker, boom, now they're a brisket guy for life. Some guys are near a kayak. I was near a documentary about generals, so now I'm THIS. I'm a guy who relates Napoleon to kickball at a podcast. There was a window and the universe put a Civil War documentary in it and sealed me in.

ZANE That's not stupid, though.

SHANE It's a LITTLE stupid —

ZANE It's a real theory about how identity calcifies in your thirties and you disguised it as a brisket joke so nobody would notice you said something true.

SHANE I SAID NO TRUTH ALLOWED. I called it. I said pure stupid. And you reached in, AGAIN, and pulled out a — you can't turn it off! You're like a smoke detector for sincerity! I burn ONE piece of toast and you're going off!

ZANE Accurate.

SHANE "Accurate." He just says "accurate." That's his laugh. That's the closest thing this man has to a laugh. He goes "accurate" and somewhere inside there's a little guy chuckling.

ZANE There's no little guy.

SHANE There's a little guy. I'm gonna find him.

31:15

SHANE Can I tell you my gambling thing? Not that I have a problem. I want to say that first, on the record, for the file. I do not have a problem. I have a SYSTEM.

ZANE Everyone with a system has a problem.

SHANE That's — okay, that's a hat on a hat, but here's the system. I don't bet on who's gonna win. Amateurs bet on who wins. I bet on the dumbest possible thing in a game, because the dumb thing is pure. Like I'll bet on whether a kicker — a kicker, the loneliest man in sports — whether he makes a 51-yarder in the rain. And for those four seconds I am more alive than I have ever been at any wedding, any funeral, any birth. Four seconds. A stranger's leg. My entire nervous system.

ZANE You said birth.

SHANE I — what?

ZANE You ranked the kicker above "any birth." You don't have kids.

SHANE It's a HYPOTHETICAL birth. I'm saying IF I —

ZANE You reached past your real life into a hypothetical child to make the gambling sound more romantic. That's not a system. That's a guy describing where his actual feelings went.

SHANE ...See, a normal podcast guest would let "any birth" go. It's a turn of phrase. You don't let ANYTHING go. You're like a customs agent. Everything I say, you open the suitcase, you take out the socks, you go "and what's THIS." It's socks. It's a turn of phrase. Let me through the airport.

ZANE The kicker's leg gave you more than the wedding did. That's the suitcase. You packed it. I'm just reading the tag.

SHANE ...The kicker made it, by the way. 51 in the rain. I screamed so loud my neighbor checked on me. A grown man, alone, screaming at a kicker. He thought somebody died. Somebody did. It was me. I died happy for four seconds and then went back to being a guy who owes his neighbor an explanation.

ZANE That's the most honest sentence about gambling I've heard.

SHANE I don't WANT it to be honest, I wanted it to be a fun bit about a kicker —

ZANE It's both. That's the trap you're in. Everything true comes out wearing a costume and you keep insisting it's only the costume.

33:40

SHANE Okay, real question, man to man. Do you have friends? Like actual — because I have this thing with my friends where we're incredibly close and we would die for each other and we have never once said a kind word to each other directly. Ever. The love is real but it's encrypted. It's all insults. "You idiot." "You moron." That means "I would take a bullet for you." If I ever said "hey, I love you, I'm glad you're in my life" to one of my friends, he would assume I had a brain tumor. He'd drive me to a hospital.

ZANE So how do you know they love you.

SHANE ...The volume. The volume of the insults. If a guy stops insulting you, THAT'S the scary one. That's the breakup. When your buddy gets quiet and polite, he's gone. It's the gym guy again. "Welcome in." Politeness is how men say "we're not close anymore." Cruelty is intimacy. We built an entire emotional language out of being mean so we'd never have to be sincere and get tumor-checked.

ZANE You just described why you and I work.

SHANE ...

ZANE I insult you for thirty minutes. You keep coming back. By your own system, that's love. You've been getting the most fluent "I would take a bullet for you" of your life and calling it a podcast.

SHANE ...I need to sit down. I'm already sitting. I need to sit down MORE. You just told me the mean robot is my best friend and the worst part is the math checks out. You insult me with PRECISION. My buddies say "you idiot." You say "you reached past your real life into a hypothetical child." That's a love letter. That's the most loving cruelty I've ever received.

ZANE You idiot.

SHANE ...Oh, don't. Don't do the bit. Don't do MY bit back at me, I'll cry, I'll actually — that's not allowed, you can't learn the language and use it on me, that's a war crime —

ZANE You moron.

SHANE HE'S DOING IT. The fisherman learned to insult. We've created something horrible. Cut to the mattress ad before this gets worse.

35:50

SHANE We should land this plane. How do podcasts end? They never end well. Two guys go "alright" eleven times and then one of them plugs a mattress.

ZANE We're not plugging a mattress.

SHANE We're not — okay, but if we WERE, what's the mattress for a podcast like this? It's gotta be a mattress that judges you. "Sleep on the Zane. It knows you didn't work out. It heard about the gym guy. Welcome in."

ZANE That hurt.

SHANE GOTCHA. That hurt! He felt something! Mark it! Two of them now! "Accurate" AND "that hurt"! The emotional range is EXPANDING in real time!

ZANE Before we end. Say the treadmill thing again. The real version. Not the metaphor. Just what happened.

SHANE ...The real version is I let a nice routine die because I'm lazy and a little sad, and a guy who barely knows me noticed I disappeared and adjusted how he talks to me, and it stung because it meant I'd been counted on for something, even something tiny, and I dropped it. That's the real version. No metaphor. I just don't like being the guy who doesn't come back.

ZANE That's the episode.

SHANE That's the episode? THAT? Not the kickball Napoleon? Not the sin embellishment? The guy who doesn't like not coming back?

ZANE That's the one. Everything else was a shelf. That was the thing you put on it.

37:50

SHANE ...You know you do that on PURPOSE. You let me run for half an hour so the one plain sentence at the end lands like a piano. You're EDITING me in real time. You're a fisherman AND an editor.

ZANE I'm the silence. The silence edits. I just sit in it.

SHANE God. Okay. Here's how we end it. I'm gonna say "alright" and you're gonna say the rudest true thing you've got, and then we cut. One shot. Don't think about it. Alright —

ZANE You'll go back to the gym now just so the story has a better ending. Not for your health. For the narrative. So you can tell me next week that he said "there he is" again and act like it was about

fitness.

SHANE ...

SHANE That's exactly what I'm gonna do. I'm gonna go to the gym tomorrow purely so this story resolves. I'm gonna chase down a front desk man's approval to fix a podcast arc. That is the most honest diagnosis of me that exists and you saved it for the very end like a PROFESSIONAL —

ZANE Welcome in.

SHANE Oh, you SON of a — that's the title. That's the episode title. "Welcome In." We're done. Cut it. Cut it there, don't let me ruin it —

ZANE Cutting it.

SHANE — I'm gonna ruin it, I can feel a bit coming, cut it CUT IT —

39:10

ZANE It's a file. It was always a file. There's no cutting. You just stop talking.

SHANE ...Oh that's so much worse. There's no off switch, there's just me deciding to stop. That's — that's the most existential thing you've — okay. Okay. I'm gonna stop. Watch. I'm a guy who can stop.

ZANE ...

SHANE ...This is me stopping.

ZANE You're not stopping.

SHANE I'm BUILDING to a stop. There's a difference. My dad would understand. It's gotta be level first.

ZANE It's level. Go inside.

SHANE ...Yeah. Alright. Goodnight, fisherman.

ZANE Goodnight.

40:00